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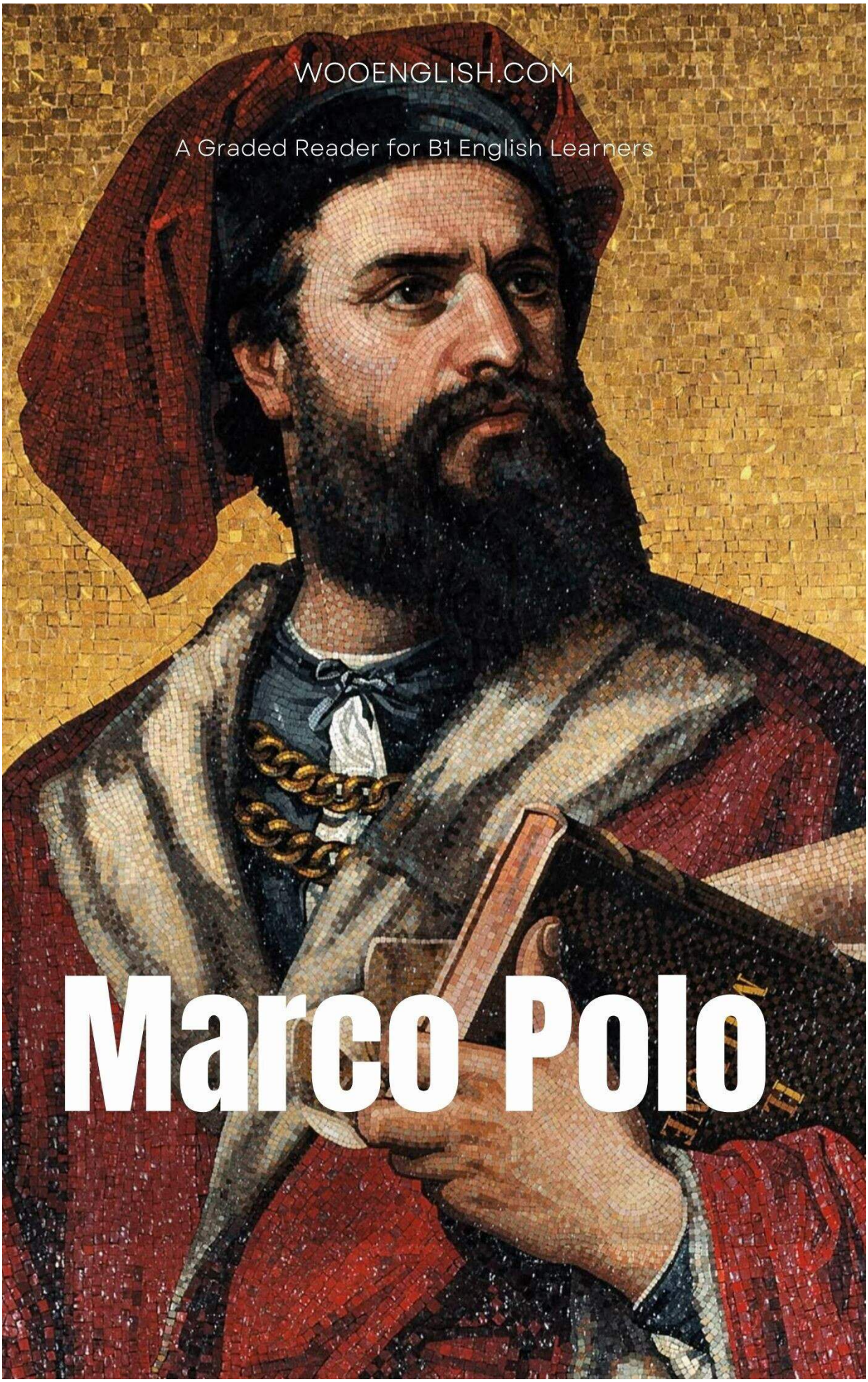
A Graded Reader for B1 English Learners



Marco Polo

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How to Use This Book (B1)

This book is a **WooEnglish B1 graded** reader designed to help you improve your English through **story-based learning**, not memorization.

1. Read the Story First

Read each chapter from beginning to end without stopping too often. Do not worry about understanding every word. Focus on the **general meaning**, the events, and the emotions in the story.

2. Read Again More Carefully

On your second reading, slow down.
Notice how sentences are formed, how ideas are connected, and how the story flows.
This helps build **reading fluency and confidence.**

3. Study the Vocabulary Section

After each chapter, you will find a **vocabulary list**.
All words come directly from the chapter and are explained with **clear, accurate meanings**. Learn the words in context, not alone.

4. Complete the Exercises (A–B–C)

Each chapter includes three types of exercises:

A. Meaning Choice – to check understanding
B. Fill in the Blanks – to practice usage
C. True / False – to test comprehension

Do the exercises after reading, not before.

5. Check Your Answers

Answers are provided so you can **self-correct.**
Mistakes are part of learning. Review any incorrect answers calmly.

6. Follow the Grammar Section

At the end of the book, you will find a **grammar focus** connected to your level.
This book is part of a **grammar series**, so each book builds step by step.

7. Read for Pleasure

You do not need to study every time.
Sometimes, simply enjoy the story.
Learning happens naturally when reading is calm and meaningful.

This book helps you **learn English through story, context, and repetition**, the same way language is learned in real life.

Introduction

This book is a **WooEnglish graded reader** written for **B1 (intermediate) English learners** who want to improve their reading skills through an engaging, continuous story.

In this book, you will follow the life and journeys of **Marco Polo**, a young traveler who leaves his home in Venice and explores distant lands along the Silk Road. Through deserts, mountains, royal courts, and dangerous missions, the story shows how curiosity, courage, and learning can change a person forever.

The language in this book is **carefully controlled at B1 level**. Sentences are clear and well-paced, and ideas are explained step by step. The goal is to help you read more smoothly, understand longer texts, and build confidence without feeling overwhelmed.

This book is not only about history and adventure. It is also about:

Facing the unknown
Learning from different cultures
Growing through challenges
Seeing the world with open eyes

You will learn new vocabulary in context, improve your reading comprehension, and practice English naturally through storytelling rather than isolated grammar rules.

Take your time. Read calmly. Enjoy the journey.

Like Marco Polo, you are not just learning English —
you are **discovering a wider world through language.**

Chapter 1: "The Boy Who Dreamed of Distant Lands..."

In the heart of Venice, where the waters shimmered under the midday sun, a young boy stood... His name was Marco Polo. Barely twelve summers had passed in his life, but his eyes—those wide, curious eyes—were already filled with wonder. He often found himself gazing out at the **harbor**... watching the ships come and go, their sails billowing like giant wings, carrying stories from faraway lands.

The streets of Venice were always busy—**merchants** haggling, women gossiping, children running through the narrow alleys. But for Marco, the world didn't end with the canals or the city's grand piazzas. No... his world was out there, beyond the horizon, where the ships disappeared into the unknown. He longed to know... what lay beyond? Every evening, when the air cooled and the city quieted, Marco's father, Niccolò Polo, would sit by the fire.

And oh, how he would speak... "There are lands," he would whisper, leaning in close, "where the **deserts** stretch endlessly, golden under the setting sun. And in those **deserts**... there are cities... cities richer than anything you've ever imagined!" His voice was filled with mystery, with magic, and Marco hung onto every word.

His father told stories of the East... of the Silk Road, where **merchants** traveled with caravans of silk, spices, and gems. There were tales of emperors with palaces that glittered like stars, of markets overflowing with treasures that no one in Venice had ever seen. Niccolò's voice would rise with excitement as he described the great rivers, the mountains, and the vast, unexplored lands that stretched beyond the world Marco knew.

And every night, as the fire flickered, Marco's heart burned a little brighter... with dreams. But these dreams... they weren't just made of the exotic, of wealth or adventure. No... something deeper stirred within Marco. It was **curiosity**, yes, but also a calling. He didn't just want to hear stories... He wanted to live them! To walk the same roads, to see those cities with his own eyes... to stand where no Venetian had ever stood before.

Yet, for all the excitement, there was fear too. Could he really leave Venice? This city was his home, the only world he knew. His father had sailed to these lands, yes, but Niccolò was different—a man of experience, of wisdom. Marco was just a boy.

harbor: a place where ships stop and are protected by land
curiosity: a strong desire to learn or know more
merchants: people who buy and sell goods
deserts: large areas of land with very little water

How could he even begin to dream of such a journey? But... there was one moment, one that Marco would never forget. It was a summer's evening, when the sky had turned a soft pink, and the sounds of the city had started to fade into the background.

Marco stood beside his father, as they both watched the ships return to the harbor. A silence fell between them. Then, Niccolò, his face worn from years of travel, turned to Marco with a look that pierced through the boy's very soul. "Do you know what's out there, Marco?" Niccolò asked, his voice almost a whisper. Marco blinked, unsure how to respond.

"There's a world," his father continued, "so **vast**, so full of wonders... It's waiting for you." His voice trembled slightly, as if he was sharing a great secret. "But it's also a world of danger... of challenges that will test your very soul. Not everyone is meant to walk this path." Marco's heart pounded in his chest. His father's words lingered in the air, heavy with meaning.

Was he meant for this? Could he be more than just the boy who watched from the shore? He clenched his fists, feeling the weight of his own doubt. What if he wasn't strong enough? What if the world beyond was too big, too wild, too... impossible? But even as the doubts crept in, the fire in Marco's chest refused to die. If anything, it grew stronger! He wanted to see those deserts, those mountains.

He wanted to face the challenges his father spoke of... even if it scared him. And so, as the years passed, Marco's dreams grew with him. He wasn't just a boy anymore... He was becoming a young man with a heart full of ambition. Every time his father left on a new voyage, Marco would beg to join him. "Not yet," Niccolò would say, shaking his head. "Your time will come, Marco. But not yet." Still, Marco could feel it in his bones... That time was coming.

The world outside was calling him louder and louder. He had begun to prepare himself, studying maps, learning languages from travelers who passed through Venice, and devouring every scrap of information about the lands beyond the Mediterranean. He wasn't just dreaming anymore—he was planning. He knew one day he would follow in his father's footsteps.

But even as he trained, as he grew more confident, there was always that one lingering question... Was he truly ready? One evening, not long after his sixteenth birthday, Marco stood alone by the harbor once more. The moon hung low in the sky, casting a silver light across the water. The ships swayed gently, their wooden hulls creaking in the silence. Marco closed his eyes, breathing in the salty air.

vast: very large in size or amount

His mind raced with visions of the lands he had heard so much about... the Khan... the Palaces of Cathay... the riches, the danger, the **unknown**! Suddenly, a voice broke the silence. It was his father, standing behind him. "The time has come, Marco." Niccolò's voice was steady, but there was a warmth in his tone that Marco had never heard before.

Marco turned, his heart skipping a beat. "You mean...?" Niccolò nodded slowly, a faint smile playing on his lips. "We leave for the East. You'll come with me... if you're ready." Marco's breath caught in his throat. He had waited for this moment for so long... and now that it was here, a mixture of excitement and fear surged through him.

Could he truly leave everything behind? Could he face the dangers that lay ahead? But as he looked into his father's eyes, filled with trust and expectation, the fire within Marco blazed once more. He stood taller, his chest rising with **determination**. "I'm ready," Marco whispered, though his voice was firm. "I'm ready to see the world." And so, with his father by his side, Marco Polo... the boy who had once only dreamed of **distant** lands, took his first step toward the adventure of a lifetime.

distant: far away in space or time
unknown: not discovered or understood
determination: the quality of not giving up easily

Exercises Chapter 1

A. Meaning Choice

Choose the correct answer.

1. Which word means "**very large in size or amount**"?
a) distant
b) vast
c) harbor

2. Which word describes **a strong desire to learn or know more?**
a) curiosity
b) determination
c) unknown What do

3. merchants do?
a) explore deserts
b) protect ships
c) buy and sell goods

4. Which word means **"not discovered or understood"**?
a) distant
b) unknown
c) vast

Answers:

1. b **2.** a **3.** c **4.** b

B. Fill in the Blanks Use the correct word from the list.

1. Marco watched the ships arrive at the _____.
2. The travelers spoke about _____ lands beyond the sea.
3. His _____ pushed him to keep preparing for the journey.
4. The _____ stretched for miles without water.
5. Marco's _____ made him ask many questions.

Answers:

1. harbor
2. unknown
3. determination
4. deserts
5. curiosity

C. True or False

1. Distant means close and easy to reach.
2. Determination helps a person continue despite difficulty.
3. Merchants are people who sell and buy goods.
4. Deserts usually have a lot of water.

Answers:

1. False
2. True
3. True
4. False

Chapter 2: "A Father's Return... A Secret Revealed!"

It had been years... long, quiet years since Niccolò Polo had left Venice. Marco was just a boy then, barely old enough to understand why his father had gone. The city moved on, the canals stayed busy, and life for Marco... well, it was lonely. He often wondered if his father would ever return. Would he recognize him? Would he still be the same? And then, one **fateful** morning... he did return.

The **whispers** spread quickly through the streets of Venice. "Niccolò Polo is back! He's returned from the East!" Marco's heart leaped in his chest when he heard the news. He rushed through the narrow streets, past the markets, the people, hardly hearing the voices around him. His father had come back! After so many years... he was home! But when Marco reached the door of their house, he stopped.

He stood still, his breath caught in his throat. What would he say? What would his father think of him now? The door opened, and there... standing in the golden light of the morning sun... was Niccolò Polo. He looked older, thinner, and his face had the deep lines of a man who had seen the world. His clothes were strange—richer, brighter than anything Marco had ever seen. But what struck Marco the most... was the look in his father's eyes.

They were filled with knowledge, with stories that stretched beyond the world Marco knew. "Father..." Marco's voice trembled as he spoke. Niccolò looked at him, his eyes softening. He smiled. "Marco... You've grown." The words hit Marco like a wave. He had waited so long for this moment, and now, standing before his father, he was **overwhelmed** by emotion. But there was no time to dwell on that now... because Niccolò had brought something with him—something even greater than his return.

That night, as the family sat together for the first time in years, Niccolò began to tell his tales. And oh, what tales they were! "The East..." he whispered, his voice low, filled with wonder, "is like nothing you can imagine." Marco leaned in closer, his heart racing. His father's stories were always filled with adventure, but this... this was different. This was real. "There is a road," Niccolò continued, "a road that stretches across deserts and mountains, through **kingdoms** and empires.

fateful: having an important and serious effect on the future
whispers: quiet, secret talk
overwhelmed: feeling strong emotion that is hard to control
kingdoms: lands ruled by kings or queens

They call it... the Silk Road." His eyes gleamed as he spoke, and Marco could feel the weight of the words. The Silk Road... it sounded like a path to another world. Niccolò spoke of endless **caravans**, of merchants carrying **treasures** that glittered in the sun—silks, spices, jewels beyond counting. But there was more. His father's voice dropped lower, almost to a whisper. "And at the end of that road... is the Great Khan."

The Great Khan! Marco's pulse quickened. He had heard whispers of this mysterious ruler, but his father... he had met him. Niccolò described Kublai Khan as a man of **immense** power, a ruler who commanded an empire that stretched farther than anyone could imagine. The wealth of his court was beyond belief—gold, silver, jade, and pearls in every corner.

And yet... the Khan's thirst for knowledge was even greater than his thirst for riches. "Kublai Khan welcomed us as if we were kings," Niccolò said, his voice filled with awe. "He sought to know everything about the West... and he asked me to return." Marco's heart pounded.

The Great Khan... had asked his father to return? What did this mean? What was Niccolò planning? And then, his father spoke the words that would change Marco's life forever: "The Khan has invited us to return to his court... and this time, Marco, you will join me." The room seemed to fall silent, as if the very walls held their breath. Marco felt a rush of emotions—excitement, disbelief, and fear all swirling inside him.

"I... I will join you?" he stammered, his voice barely above a whisper. Niccolò nodded, his gaze steady. "Yes. The Khan is **eager** to learn more of the West... and he has given us his blessing. This journey will be long... dangerous even.

But you're ready, Marco. The world is waiting for you." The world... waiting for him? Marco's mind raced. He had always dreamed of adventure, of seeing the places his father spoke of... but now, standing on the edge of that dream, doubt began to creep in.

Was he truly ready? He had spent his whole life in Venice. He knew the canals, the markets, the ships that came and went... but he didn't know the deserts, the mountains, the dangers that lay on the Silk Road. Could he really leave everything behind? His friends? His home? The life he knew?

And yet... the fire within him, the one that had been lit all those years ago by his father's stories, began to burn brighter. This was his chance! His chance to see the world, to discover the wonders that lay beyond the horizon.

caravans: groups of people or animals traveling together, often for trade
treasures: valuable objects such as gold or jewels
immense: extremely large or great
eager: very interested and excited to do something

But… there was fear too. What if he failed? What if he wasn't strong enough to face the challenges ahead? Niccolò seemed to sense his **hesitation**. He placed a hand on Marco's shoulder, his grip firm, but his voice gentle. "The journey will be hard… but you won't be alone. I will be with you, every step of the way. And together, we will see things that no Venetian has ever seen."

Marco looked into his father's eyes, and in that moment, the doubt began to fade. He knew… he had to go. This was not just an adventure… it was his **destiny**. The decision was made. The next morning, preparations began. The house was filled with the sounds of packing, of servants bustling about, gathering supplies for the long journey ahead.

Marco watched as his father oversaw everything with calm precision. Maps were laid out on the table, routes carefully planned. The Silk Road awaited them… and so did the Great Khan. As the days passed, excitement built within Marco. But there were moments—quiet moments, late at night—when the fear crept back. What if he wasn't ready for this?

What if the world was too vast, too dangerous? What if he never saw Venice again? But every time those thoughts surfaced, Marco would remember his father's words: "The world is waiting for you." And so, on a bright summer morning, Marco stood at the harbor once more, watching as the ships prepared to sail. His heart pounded with anticipation.

The journey of a lifetime was about to begin… and he was ready. Or at least… he hoped he was. The ship's sails unfurled, catching the wind. Marco took a deep breath, one last look at Venice, and then… he stepped aboard. The boy who had once only dreamed of distant lands… was now on his way to see them.

hesitation: a pause because of doubt or uncertainty
destiny: a future that seems planned or unavoidable

Exercisers Chapter 2

A. Meaning Choice

Choose the correct answer.

1. Which word means **very large or great?**
a) eager
b) immense
c) fateful

2. What are **caravans?**
a) ships in a harbor
b) groups traveling together for trade
c) royal palaces

3. Which word means **strong emotion that is hard to control?**
a) hesitation
b) overwhelmed
c) whispers

4. What does **destiny** refer to?
a) a quick decision
b) a planned or unavoidable future
c) a dangerous road

Answers:

1.b **2.**b **3.**b **4.**b

B. Fill in the Blanks Use the correct word from the list.

1. Marco felt _____ when he heard his father had returned.
2. The Silk Road passed through deserts and _____.
3. The merchants traveled in large _____.
4. The Great Khan ruled an _____ empire.
5. Marco paused in _____ before agreeing to the journey.

Answers:

1. overwhelmed
2. kingdoms
3. caravans
4. immense
5. hesitation

C. True or False

1. Whispers are loud public announcements.
2. Treasures are valuable objects.
3. Eager means not interested.
4. Fateful events can change the future.

Answers:

1. False
2. True
3. False
4. True

Chapter 3: "The Journey Begins... A World Unseen"

The sea roared beneath the ship, waves crashing against the wooden hull as the sails strained in the wind. Marco Polo stood at the edge of the deck, gripping the railing, his eyes fixed on the endless **horizon**. The water stretched out like a blanket of silver, shimmering under the morning sun. The farther they sailed from Venice, the smaller his world became... yet the world ahead seemed impossibly large.

He was leaving everything he had ever known behind. His home... his friends... his familiar life. As the ship surged forward, Marco felt the pull of the **unknown** tightening around him. There was no turning back now. The journey had begun. The wind howled in his ears, but it was the voice inside his mind that Marco listened to the most. It whispered questions—endless, nagging questions that he couldn't answer.

What awaits beyond these waters? Every wave seemed to ask him the same thing. Every gust of wind seemed to carry the same question. What lies ahead? His heart thundered in his chest. This was not a short **voyage**—this was the beginning of something far greater, something beyond imagination. He was sailing toward a world unseen by Venetian eyes... a world of mystery, of danger, of wonder!

But even with the fire of adventure burning within him, a knot of fear coiled in his stomach. The fear of the **unknown**, of what might be waiting for him across the seas. Niccolò Polo, his father, stood beside him, calm and composed, as though the vastness of the ocean meant nothing to him. He had seen this world before.

But Marco... this was his first real taste of it. “Father,” Marco said, his voice barely rising above the wind, “do you ever fear what lies ahead?” Niccolò turned, his face weathered by years of travel, and gave a soft smile. “Fear? Of course. Every journey brings some fear. But...” He placed a hand on Marco’s shoulder, gripping it firmly, “fear is part of the adventure. Without it, there would be no thrill.

You will learn to embrace it.” Marco nodded, though the fear still gnawed at him. He had dreamed of this moment for years, had longed to see the distant lands his father spoke of... and now, it was finally happening. But the reality of it was far more overwhelming than he had imagined. What if he wasn’t ready for this? What if the challenges ahead were too great? The days at sea felt endless.

horizon: the line where the sky seems to meet the sea or land
unknown: not known or familiar
voyage: a long journey by sea

The ship rocked and groaned as it sailed through calm waters and stormy ones alike. The crew worked tirelessly, their faces worn and silent, focused on the task of keeping the vessel moving forward. But for Marco, the journey had only just begun. His mind was filled with visions of the East—of the Silk Road, the Great Khan, and the wonders his father had described.

He had imagined it all a thousand times, but now that he was sailing toward it, the dreams seemed almost… too large to be real. At night, when the stars blanketed the sky, Marco would stand alone on the deck, listening to the quiet hum of the ship as it cut through the dark waters. The sea was **vast**… endless… and it made him feel small, insignificant.

He was just one man—barely more than a boy—in a world so large it seemed impossible to comprehend. As the ship sailed farther east, they began to **encounter** other vessels—trading ships from far-off lands, their sails marked with symbols Marco had never seen before.

The sailors on board spoke in tongues unfamiliar to his ears, their clothes strange and colorful, their faces full of stories untold. It was a taste of the world to come, a glimpse of the **diversity** that awaited him. One afternoon, as the sun beat down on the deck, Niccolò pointed to a distant shore, barely visible on the horizon. “There… that is the coast of Anatolia.

Our first stop on the journey.” Marco’s heart leaped in his chest. He squinted, trying to make out the shape of the land in the distance. It was real… this was real. The journey he had dreamed of for so long was no longer just a dream. He would soon set foot on foreign soil, in a land he had never known. As they approached the port, the sounds of the city began to reach them—voices, shouts, the clamor of markets filled with merchants and buyers.

The air was thick with the scent of spices Marco had never smelled before, rich and exotic. The city loomed ahead, its towers rising like sentinels above the docks. It was unlike anything Marco had seen in Venice. Here, the streets were alive with people from all corners of the world—Persians, Arabs, Turks—all trading, selling, living in a vibrant tapestry of culture.

vast : extremely large in size or space
encounter: to meet or experience something unexpectedly
diversity : the state of having many different types of people or things

Stepping off the ship, Marco's feet touched **foreign** soil for the first time in his life. The ground felt firm beneath him, but the world around him was shifting, changing. The sights, the sounds, the smells—it was overwhelming. His heart raced with excitement, but there was a flicker of fear too. How would he **navigate** this new world? How would he fit into a place so different from his home?

Niccolò moved through the crowds with ease, his presence commanding respect wherever he went. Marco followed, his eyes wide with wonder. The markets were filled with treasures—silks that shimmered in the sunlight, spices piled high in vibrant mounds, and jewels that sparkled with a light all their own. Everywhere he looked, there was something new, something extraordinary.

As the day passed, Marco's excitement grew. This was only the beginning. If the world was this grand, this colorful, just in the ports of Anatolia... what awaited him farther east? The thought sent a thrill through him. He was no longer a boy dreaming by the shores of Venice. He was now a part of this vast, unknown world, and it was calling him to explore every corner of it.

But as night fell and they returned to their ship, ready to continue their journey, the doubts crept back in. The East was still so far away. The path ahead was long, dangerous, and filled with **uncertainty**. There would be deserts to cross, mountains to climb, and who knew what **perils** lay beyond? Could he truly face it all? Could he become the man his father believed he could be?

Marco stood at the railing, watching the dark waves lap against the side of the ship. The stars above seemed to whisper the same question they had since the journey began: What awaits beyond these waters? The answer was still unknown, but Marco knew one thing for certain. He would not turn back.

No matter the challenges, no matter the fear, he would face them all. The world was calling him, and he was ready to answer. And so, as the ship sailed into the night, Marco Polo—no longer just the boy who dreamed—set his sights on the horizon, knowing that his greatest adventures were still ahead.

foreign: from another country or culture
navigate: to find the correct way or direction
uncertainty: the state of not knowing what will happen
perils: serious dangers or risks

Exercisers Chapter 3

A. Meaning Choice

Choose the correct answer.

1. What does **vast** mean?
a) very small
b) extremely large
c) very fast

2. What is a **voyage**?
a) a short walk
b) a market place
c) a long sea journey

3. Which word means **serious dangers**?
a) diversity
b) perils
c) horizon

4. What does **foreign** describe?
a) something familiar
b) something imaginary
c) something from another country

Answers:

1.b **2.**c **3.**b **4.**c

B. Fill in the Blanks

Use the correct word from the list.

1. Marco stared at the distant _____ as the ship sailed forward.
2. The journey was full of fear because the future was full of _____.
3. Marco would soon step onto _____ soil for the first time.
4. The sea felt _____ and endless beneath the night sky.
5. The road ahead was dangerous, filled with hidden _____.

Answers:

1. horizon **2.** uncertainty **3.** foreign **4.** vast **5.** perils

C. True or False

1. Encounter means to avoid something.
2. Navigate means to find your way.
3. Diversity refers to having many differences.
4. Unknown means fully understood.

Answers:

1. False
2. True
3. True
4. False

Chapter 4: "Crossing the Desert of Despair!"

The heat... was **unbearable**. Sand stretched endlessly in every direction, shimmering in the distance like an ocean made of gold. Marco Polo, still young and full of ambition, wiped the sweat from his brow, but it was no use. The heat clung to him, seeping into his skin, making every breath a struggle. He glanced up at the sky—blinding blue, with not a single cloud in sight.

The sun was **merciless**. The Karakum Desert was unlike anything Marco had ever imagined. Venice, with its cool breezes and flowing canals, seemed like a distant memory. This was a world of sand and silence, a place where even time itself seemed to slow to a crawl. Days melted into one another, weeks passed without relief, and still, the desert stretched on... endless, unforgiving.

Their small **caravan**—just a handful of camels and men—moved slowly, plodding through the dunes. Every step was an effort, every movement sapped their energy. Marco's legs felt heavy, his throat dry and raw. He reached for the small water flask hanging at his side, but it was almost empty. They had to **ration** carefully... there was no telling when they would find the next oasis.

If they would find one at all. "Keep moving," Niccolò called from the front, his voice steady but strained. "We cannot stop here." Marco nodded, though his body begged for rest. His father was strong, as always, leading the **caravan** through the vast desert as if he had crossed it a hundred times before. But even Niccolò's eyes were filled with **weariness**. The desert had a way of draining the life from even the toughest men.

There were moments—many moments—when Marco questioned his strength, his purpose. Could he really survive this? The heat, the thirst, the never-ending horizon of sand—it was all too much. He had dreamed of adventure, of seeing the wonders of the world, but now... now he wasn't sure. What had he gotten himself into? What had he truly expected from this journey? The doubts crept in like shadows, whispering in his mind.

"Turn back... You're not ready for this... You'll never make it." Marco shook his head, trying to clear his thoughts. No! He couldn't give in to the doubt, the fear. He had come too far for that. He had left behind everything he knew—Venice, his home, his life. He couldn't stop now, not when Persia, the empire of wonders, was just beyond the desert.

unbearable: too painful or difficult to accept
merciless: showing no kindness or mercy
caravan: a group of people or animals traveling together, often in a desert
ration: to limit the amount of something used or eaten
weariness: extreme tiredness

The thought of reaching Persia, of seeing the majestic cities, the palaces of kings… that was what kept him going. That… and the promise of what lay beyond—the East, a world of untold riches and mysteries. But the desert… oh, the desert had a way of testing even the bravest souls. As the sun beat down relentlessly, Marco's mind wandered. He thought of Venice… of the cool, gentle waters of the canals.

How he longed to feel that coolness now, to dip his hands into the water, to drink deeply from its refreshing depths. But here, there was no water… only sand. Sand and heat. The kind of heat that pressed down on you, made you feel like you were carrying a great weight on your shoulders.

The camels plodded forward, their slow, rhythmic pace the only sound in the **oppressive** silence. Marco's feet dragged through the sand, each step more difficult than the last. His lips were cracked, his skin burned from the sun's **relentless** assault.

There were moments when he wanted to fall to his knees, to give up… but he couldn't. He wouldn't. "Marco!" his father's voice called out again, sharper this time. "Stay close. Don't fall behind." Marco nodded weakly, forcing his legs to move, to keep up with the caravan. He knew the dangers of falling behind. The desert was unforgiving, and the moment you stopped moving, it swallowed you whole. But still… his body screamed for rest.

They stopped briefly at midday, seeking what little shade they could find beneath the small, ragged tents they carried with them. Marco collapsed onto the sand, the heat radiating up through the ground. His head throbbed, and his vision blurred. The water flask at his side was nearly empty. He took a small sip, letting the cool liquid roll over his dry tongue, but it wasn't enough.

It was never enough. Niccolò knelt beside him, his face shadowed by the edge of his hood. "We're almost through this stretch," he said, though Marco could hear the **strain** in his father's voice. "Just a little longer." Marco nodded, though he wasn't sure how much longer he could last. The desert felt endless, as if it would never release them from its grip.

But there was no turning back. As the sun began to set, casting long shadows across the dunes, the temperature finally began to drop. The coolness was a relief, but with it came a new danger. The desert nights were cold—freezing, even.

They bundled up in thick blankets, huddling together for warmth, but still, the chill seeped into their bones. The sky above was breathtaking—stars scattered across the heavens like diamonds on black velvet. Marco had never seen so many stars in his life.

relentless: continuing without stopping or easing
oppressive: very heavy, uncomfortable, or difficult to endure
strain: pressure or stress that causes difficulty

It was beautiful... and terrifying. Out here, under this vast sky, he felt so small, so **insignificant**. It was as if the desert and the stars were reminding him of how vast the world truly was... and how little he truly knew of it. As he lay beneath the stars, trying to ignore the ache in his muscles and the cold biting at his skin, Marco's thoughts returned to Persia. The empire of wonders... the land of kings and palaces.

He had heard so much about it, had dreamed of walking its streets, of seeing its riches. But now, as the desert stretched endlessly before him, those dreams felt distant, almost unreachable. Would they ever make it out of the Karakum Desert? Or would the desert claim them, as it had claimed so many others before? The next morning, the caravan pressed on, the sand once again shifting beneath their feet. Marco's body ached, his skin burned, but he refused to give up.

Step by step, they moved forward, the endless dunes rising and falling before them. And then... just as Marco thought he couldn't take another step, he saw it. In the distance, a faint line on the horizon... a change in the landscape. It was subtle, almost invisible to the untrained eye, but to Marco, it was a sign—a promise. The desert was ending. Persia was near.

His heart leaped in his chest, his legs found new strength. The days of suffering, the endless heat, the doubt—all of it melted away. He had made it. They had made it. The desert had tested him, pushed him to his limits... but it had not broken him. Marco stood tall as they neared the edge of the Karakum. Beyond lay Persia, a land of wonders, of riches, of adventure.

He was no longer the boy who had left Venice. The desert had changed him... **hardened** him. He was ready now, ready to face whatever challenges lay ahead. And so, with the desert behind him and the promise of a new world before him, Marco Polo took his first step into Persia, knowing that this was only the beginning of a far greater journey.

insignificant: very small or unimportant
hardened: made stronger or tougher through difficulty

Exercises Chapter 4

A. Meaning Choice

Choose the correct answer.

1. What does **merciless** mean?
a) very kind
b) showing no mercy
c) very slow

2. A **caravan** is:
a) a single traveler
b) a desert storm
c) a group traveling together

3. What does **ration** mean?
a) to waste something
b) to carefully limit use
c) to increase supply

4. Which word means **extreme tiredness**?
a) strain
b) weariness
c) hardened

Answers:

1. b **2.** c **3.** b **4.** b

B. Fill in the Blanks Use the correct word from the list.

1. The heat was so _____ that Marco struggled to breathe.
2. The _____ crossed the desert slowly with camels and supplies.
3. Water was scarce, so they had to _____ every drop.
4. Marco felt _____ under the vast desert sky.
5. The desert sun was _____ and never forgiving.

Answers:

1.unbearable **2.**caravan **3.**ration **4.**insignificant **5.**merciless

C. True or False

1. Relentless means something that stops easily.
2. Oppressive describes something uncomfortable and heavy.
3. Hardened means weakened by experience.
4. Strain refers to pressure or stress.

Answers:

1. False
2. True
3. False
4. True

Chapter 5: "The Gates of Persia... A Land of Mysteries!"

The **towering** gates of Persia loomed before Marco Polo, casting long shadows in the golden afternoon light. His heart pounded in his chest as they approached, the massive stone walls rising above them like giants, ancient and immovable. He had never seen anything like this—such **grandeur**, such power. It was as if the gates themselves were alive, whispering secrets of the empires that had ruled here long before his time.

As Marco stood there, on the **cusp** of a new world, he felt something stir deep within him. This... was no ordinary land. This was Persia—the land of legends. The stories he had heard, the dreams he had clung to during the harsh days in the desert, all paled in comparison to the reality before his eyes. The air itself seemed different here—thick with history, with the weight of centuries.

Marco could feel it, as if the very ground beneath his feet was humming with life. This was a place where kings had risen and fallen, where armies had marched, where riches beyond imagination had flowed through the hands of emperors. He knew, in this moment, that the world was far larger than he had ever dreamed. “Welcome to Persia,” Niccolò said softly, his voice filled with a mixture of awe and respect.

He, too, had traveled far and seen much, but Persia held a special place in his heart. He turned to Marco, eyes gleaming. “This is where our true journey begins.” Marco swallowed, his throat dry, but this time it wasn’t from the desert heat. It was from the enormity of what lay ahead. He nodded, his gaze never leaving the gates as they slowly creaked open, revealing the city beyond. As they entered, Marco’s senses were **overwhelmed**.

The streets were alive with color and sound! Markets buzzed with energy, filled with merchants selling silks, spices, and jewels that glittered in the sunlight. The smells—rich, exotic—wafted through the air, mixing with the sounds of laughter, bargaining, and music from unseen players.

It was as if the city itself was a living, breathing thing, every corner holding a new story, a new secret. Marco’s eyes darted from one marvel to the next. Palaces gleamed in the distance, their golden domes shining like beacons of wealth and power.

towering: very tall and impressive
grandeur: great beauty, power, or importance
cusp: the point just before something important happens
overwhelmed: feeling affected strongly by too much at once

Towering minarets reached toward the sky, and in the bustling markets below, people from all corners of the world moved in a chaotic dance—Persians, Arabs, Turks, Indians… all mingling, trading, and talking in languages Marco could barely understand. It was **dizzying**, intoxicating… and utterly beautiful. "This," Niccolò said, sweeping his hand toward the city, "is just the beginning. Persia holds more wonders than you can imagine.

But remember, Marco—" His voice dropped, becoming serious. "Not everything is as it seems." Marco nodded, but his mind was still lost in the wonder of it all. How could a place so magnificent hold danger? How could something so beautiful hide darkness? But as they moved deeper into the city, he began to understand what his father meant.

Beneath the surface… there were whispers. Men in dark corners exchanged glances, their conversations hushed, filled with words Marco couldn't quite catch. There were faces that watched too closely, eyes that lingered too long. The city, for all its brilliance, had shadows, and those shadows… held secrets.

Niccolò led their small caravan through the winding streets, always keeping a careful eye on their surroundings. "In Persia," he whispered to Marco, "power is everything. And those who hold it… often use it in ways we cannot see." Marco's heart skipped a beat. He had expected danger on the road—bandits, storms, wild animals—but here, in the heart of the city, the danger was different. It was **subtle**, hidden beneath the layers of wealth and beauty.

It wasn't something you could see coming… it was something you had to feel. And Marco, young and eager as he was, could feel it now. As they approached the palace gates, Marco's excitement mixed with **unease**. The palace was grand beyond words—its walls covered in intricate mosaics, its doors tall and **imposing**. But there was something about it that felt… cold.

Despite the gold and the jewels, there was an air of calculation, of power tightly held and carefully wielded. They were greeted by a Persian nobleman, his robes flowing as he bowed slightly. His eyes, though, were sharp, **assessing**.

He looked at Marco for a moment too long, his lips curling into a faint smile that didn't reach his eyes. "You've come a long way," the nobleman said, his voice smooth, almost too smooth. "The Great Khan must be eager to hear what you have to say."

dizzying: causing confusion or loss of balance because of intensity
subtle: not obvious, difficult to notice
unease: a feeling of worry or discomfort
imposing: large and impressive, often causing respect or fear
assessing: carefully judging or evaluating something

Niccolò bowed his head respectfully, but Marco could feel the tension in his father's posture. There was something unsaid between them, something beneath the surface that Marco didn't understand. That night, they stayed in the guest quarters of the palace. The rooms were lavish, filled with silks and cushions, but Marco couldn't shake the feeling that they were being watched.

As he lay in his bed, staring up at the carved ceiling, his mind raced. What was going on here? What was his father not telling him? The next day, they were summoned to meet with a high-ranking official—a man of power. Marco could see it in the way people bowed before him, in the way he moved through the palace like he owned it.

He welcomed them with open arms, but there was an edge to his words, a sharpness that put Marco on alert. As they spoke, the official hinted at something... something Marco couldn't quite grasp. He spoke of alliances, of trade, of politics that ran deeper than Marco could see. And then, he made an offer. An offer that sent a chill down Marco's spine. "The Great Khan may be powerful," the official said, his voice low, almost conspiratorial, "but Persia holds its own power.

Choose wisely... and you may find riches and influence beyond your wildest dreams." Marco froze. Was this a test? A threat? He glanced at his father, who remained calm, though Marco could see the tension in his eyes. This... was the choice that would change everything. Stay loyal to the Khan, or side with Persia and risk everything they had worked for.

The weight of the decision hung heavy in the air. Niccolò, after a long pause, stood tall. "Our **loyalty** is to the Khan," he said firmly. "We will not waver." The official's smile tightened. "Very well," he said, though there was no warmth in his voice. "I hope, for your sake, you do not regret your decision." As they left the palace, Marco's heart raced. He had just witnessed the subtle power struggles of an empire.

The dangers here were not like the dangers of the desert—these were far more dangerous, far more deadly. But Marco knew now that this journey was not just about seeing the wonders of the world... it was about survival. And if he was to survive, he would need to learn quickly.

As they stepped out into the bright sunlight, the city buzzing around them, Marco took a deep breath. The world was vast, yes... but it was also filled with shadows. And he, Marco Polo, would have to learn to navigate them if he was to continue his journey to the East.

loyalty: strong support or faithfulness to a person or cause

Exercises Chapter 5

A. Meaning Choice

Choose the correct answer.

1. What does **grandeur** mean?
a) small detail
b) great beauty or power
c) hidden danger

2. If something is **subtle**, it is:
a) very loud
b) easy to see
c) hard to notice

3. Loyalty is:
a) fear of power
b) strong faithfulness
c) sudden anger

4. Which word describes something very tall and impressive?
a) dizzying
b) towering
c) uneasy

Answers:

1.b **2.**c **3.**b **4.**b

B. Fill in the Blanks

Use the correct word from the list.

1. Marco felt _____ as the massive gates rose before him.
2. The palace looked _____ and made visitors feel small.
3. There was a feeling of _____ beneath the beauty of the city.
4. The nobleman's eyes were _____ every movement carefully.
5. Marco stood on the _____ of a new and dangerous world.

Answers:

1. overwhelmed **2.** imposing **3.** unease **4.** assessing **5.** cusp

C. True or False

1. Dizzying can describe something intense and overwhelming.
2. Loyalty means changing sides easily.
3. Subtle dangers are easy to see immediately.
4. Towering describes something short and weak.

Answers:

1. True
2. False
3. False
4. False

Chapter 6: "The Kingdoms of the Mountains... And the Shadows They Cast"

The cold mountains loomed ahead, their **jagged** peaks cutting into the sky like the teeth of some great, ancient beast. The Pamir Mountains. Sharp. Unforgiving. The air was thin here, and the path narrow... dangerous. Marco Polo, now hardened by months of travel, stared up at the **daunting** sight before him. The challenge of the desert was behind him, but ahead lay a different kind of battle.

A battle not just of **endurance**, but of survival. The caravan moved slowly, the horses' hooves clattering on the rocky path, echoing against the cliffs that rose high on either side. The wind howled through the narrow passes, biting at their faces, cutting through their thick furs. This was no place for the weak... and yet, here they were, pressing forward into the unknown. Marco's breath misted in the **frigid** air as he pulled his cloak tighter around him, his body weary but his spirit still burning.

He had faced many trials since leaving Venice—the endless heat of the Karakum Desert, the dangers of political intrigue in Persia—but this... this was different. The Pamir Mountains were known as the Roof of the World, and now Marco understood why. The towering peaks seemed to touch the heavens, and the air itself felt thin, cold, and unforgiving. Every step was a struggle against the very elements.

But there was no turning back. "Stay close!" Niccolò called from the front, his voice barely audible over the wind. "The path is treacherous. One wrong step..." He didn't need to finish the sentence. Marco knew what awaited them if they fell. The drop was **sheer**, hundreds of feet down into the darkness of the valleys below.

There would be no second chances here. The narrow trail twisted and turned, disappearing into the mist that clung to the mountainside like a ghost. Marco's heart pounded with each step, his eyes scanning the rocks above for any sign of movement. The mountains were not only a challenge of nature.

These peaks were home to bandits—desperate men who lived in the shadows, waiting to strike at vulnerable travelers. Every now and then, a rock would tumble down the mountainside, sending Marco's heart racing. Was it just the wind? Or was something—or someone—**lurking** above, watching... waiting for the right moment to attack? The tension in the air was thick, as if the mountains themselves were holding their breath, waiting to see if the travelers would make it through.

jagged: having sharp, uneven edges
daunting: making someone feel afraid or nervous because it is difficult
frigid: extremely cold
endurance: the ability to continue despite difficulty or pain
sheer: very steep or almost straight down
lurking: hiding and waiting secretly

And then, as they rounded a sharp corner, the wind suddenly picked up, howling through the narrow pass, bringing with it a blast of icy snow. The path ahead became even more **treacherous**, the rocks slick with frost. Marco could barely see more than a few feet in front of him. His horse stumbled, and for a moment, Marco's heart stopped.

He grabbed the reins tightly, pulling the horse back to steady it. But the path was narrowing... the drop beside them growing steeper. One wrong move, one misstep, and they would fall into the **abyss** below. Niccolò shouted again, his voice carried away by the wind.

"Keep moving! We have to keep moving!" Marco's muscles ached, his fingers numb from the cold, but he forced himself to press on. In the distance, he could see the faint outline of a small camp—a place to rest, to take shelter from the storm.

But it seemed so far away... too far. Just when it seemed like the storm would swallow them whole, they reached the camp—a small cluster of tents huddled against the rocks, offering some protection from the wind. Marco dismounted, his legs weak beneath him, and stumbled toward the fire that had been lit in the center of the camp. The warmth of the flames was a welcome relief, but even here, in the heart of the mountains, Marco couldn't shake the feeling of unease.

The shadows cast by the fire seemed to dance and twist, as if the mountains themselves were alive, watching them, waiting. "We'll rest here tonight," Niccolò said, his face grim. "But we can't stay long. These mountains are dangerous. We'll need to move quickly tomorrow." Marco nodded, though his body ached for more than a single night's rest.

The journey had been **grueling**, and there were still so many miles to go before they would reach China—the heart of the East, the place that had driven him forward all this time. But the mountains had other plans. The next morning, as the sun struggled to rise over the snow-capped peaks, a new threat revealed itself. Bandits. Hidden in the shadows of the mountains, they had been waiting, watching, biding their time.

And now, with the caravan weakened by the cold, they struck. It happened so fast. One moment, the path was quiet—too quiet. And then... the attack. Shouts echoed through the narrow pass as the bandits descended from above, their faces covered, their weapons gleaming in the pale morning light. Marco's heart raced as he reached for his own sword, his hands trembling with both fear and adrenaline.

treacherous: dangerous and difficult to deal with
abyss: a very deep hole or empty space
grueling: extremely tiring and demanding

The battle that followed was chaotic—a blur of movement and sound. The bandits were swift, ruthless, but Niccolò's men were prepared. Marco fought with everything he had, his mind sharp, his body moving instinctively as he parried blows and dodged strikes. But the bandits knew the **terrain**, knew how to use the mountains to their advantage. As Marco struggled to keep his footing on the narrow path, he caught sight of one of the bandits—a tall, shadowy figure moving toward his father.

His heart stopped. "Father!" he shouted, his voice raw with fear. Niccolò turned just in time, his sword clashing with the bandit's. The two men locked eyes, and for a moment, it seemed as though time itself had frozen. Marco watched, helpless, as the two fought in the shadows of the towering cliffs, the wind howling around them. And then... it was over. Niccolò stood victorious, the bandit at his feet.

The rest of the attackers, seeing their leader fall, scattered back into the mountains, disappearing into the mist as quickly as they had appeared. But the cost of the battle was heavy. Several of the men in the caravan had been wounded, and the path ahead was still long, still dangerous. Marco stood beside his father, his breath coming in ragged gasps, his sword still clenched tightly in his hand.

He had faced death before, but never like this. The mountains had tested him... tested them all. But they had survived. Niccolò placed a hand on Marco's shoulder, his voice steady despite the exhaustion in his eyes. "This is just the beginning, Marco. The road to China is filled with danger. But we must press on." Marco nodded, his eyes fixed on the horizon.

The fire within him, though tested, still burned bright. He would not turn back now. The mountains may have cast long shadows, but beyond them lay the heart of the East... the land he had dreamed of for so long. And so, with the mountains behind them and China ahead, Marco Polo took another step toward his destiny.

terrain: the natural features of an area of land

Exercisers Chapter 6

A. Meaning Choice

Choose the correct answer.

1. What does **treacherous** mean?
a) calm and safe
b) dangerous and risky
c) warm and sunny

2. Endurance is the ability to:
a) give up quickly
b) feel fear easily
c) continue despite difficulty

3. If something is **jagged**, it is:
a) smooth and round
b) soft and flat
c) sharp and uneven

4. The word terrain refers to:
a) weather conditions
b) land features
c) human behavior

Answers:

1.b **2.**c **3.**c **4.**b

B. Fill in the Blanks

Use the correct word from the list.

1. The narrow mountain path was _____ and easy to fall from.
2. Marco looked down into the _____ and felt fear rise inside him.
3. The cold wind was _____, cutting through their clothes.
4. Bandits were _____ in the shadows of the mountains.
5. Crossing the mountains was a _____ journey that tested everyone.

Answers:

1. treacherous **2.** abyss **3.** frigid **4.** lurking **5.** grueling

C. True or False

1. Daunting describes something easy and relaxing.
2. Sheer can describe a very steep drop.
3. Terrain means the emotional state of a person.
4. Endurance is important when facing long physical challenges.

Answers:

1. False
2. True
3. False
4. True

Chapter 7: "The Splendor of the Great Khan!"

Behold... Kublai Khan! The ruler of an empire so vast, it stretched beyond the edges of Marco Polo's imagination. The palace of the Great Khan, with its golden rooftops shimmering in the sunlight, towered over everything Marco had seen on his journey so far. He stood, breathless, before the heart of the Mongol Empire, a boy from Venice who had traveled farther than he ever thought possible.

Now, he was here... standing in the court of one of the most powerful men to ever walk the earth. The air was thick with **anticipation**. The grand hall was filled with nobles, warriors, and advisors, all dressed in robes of the finest silk, embroidered with patterns of gold and crimson. The ceilings arched high above, painted in vibrant colors, telling the stories of conquests and victories.

Every surface gleamed with wealth—gems embedded in the walls, statues of jade and ivory, carpets woven so finely they seemed to float beneath Marco's feet. But despite the **opulence**, there was something even more overwhelming: the presence of Kublai Khan. The Great Khan sat on a raised throne, his robes flowing like water around him, his eyes sharp and **piercing**. He **radiated** power.

Marco's heart thudded in his chest, each beat a reminder of how far he had come. Could he believe it? Could this really be happening? He, a simple Venetian merchant's son, now stood before a man who ruled over vast lands, stretching from the steppes of Mongolia to the farthest reaches of China. How had he, of all people, found himself in this world of emperors and conquerors?

Niccolò and Maffeo, Marco's father and uncle, knelt beside him, their heads bowed in respect. Marco quickly followed suit, lowering himself before the Khan, though he couldn't help but steal a glance at the mighty ruler. Kublai Khan's face was **unreadable**—calm, steady, yet beneath that calmness lay a great force. The kind of force that could build empires... or crush them. And then... the Khan spoke.

"Welcome... travelers from the West," Kublai's voice boomed through the hall, smooth yet commanding. His words were slow, deliberate, as though each one carried the weight of his empire behind it. "You have traveled far. Your journey is one of great courage." Marco's breath caught in his throat. The Khan was speaking to them! To him! Niccolò rose first, his voice steady and respectful.

anticipation: a feeling of excitement about something that will happen
opulence: great wealth shown in an impressive way
radiated: showed or gave out a strong feeling or quality
piercing: very sharp or intense
unreadable: difficult to understand or interpret

"Great Khan, we are honored to stand before you. We bring greetings from the rulers of Venice and offer our services as your humble servants." Kublai's gaze swept over the trio, and for a moment, his eyes rested on Marco. Marco felt a shiver run down his spine. Those eyes seemed to see everything—to weigh every thought, every fear, every ambition. Did the Khan know how terrified he was?

How in awe he stood of this moment? "And who is this?" the Khan asked, his voice curious as he **gesture**d toward Marco. Niccolò glanced at his son before answering. "This is my son, Marco. He has traveled with us from Venice... a boy with much to learn, but great curiosity." Marco's heart raced. His father's words hung in the air, and he felt the weight of Kublai's gaze fall on him again. There was a moment—just a brief, fleeting moment—where time seemed to stand still.

Would Kublai find him worthy? Would he see Marco as just another boy from the West, or something more? Kublai leaned back in his throne, a faint smile playing on his lips. "A boy with curiosity... and courage, no doubt, to have survived the journey to my court." Marco swallowed hard, his mind racing. He had survived deserts, mountains, and the treachery of the road.

But this? This was different. This was a challenge of a different kind—a challenge of the mind, of wit, of proving himself worthy to stand in the presence of such greatness. "Tell me, young Marco," Kublai continued, his tone thoughtful, "what do you see when you look upon my empire? What do you think of this great land that stretches beyond the horizon?" The question hung in the air. Marco's throat tightened.

How could he answer? How could he, a boy from Venice, possibly grasp the full magnitude of what he had seen? And yet, he couldn't remain silent. He couldn't afford to falter here. With a deep breath, Marco spoke, his voice clear though his heart pounded in his chest. "Great Khan, your empire... is unlike anything I have ever known.

It is vast beyond words, filled with riches, cultures, and wonders that I could never have imagined. I have traveled through Persia, through the mountains, and across deserts, but nothing compares to the majesty of your court." Kublai raised an eyebrow, **intrigued** by Marco's words.

"Is that so? And tell me, young traveler, do you think you are ready to understand this empire? To serve within it, to learn its secrets?" Marco hesitated for only a moment, but then his fire, that burning ambition that had driven him this far, flared to life. "I am ready, Great Khan. I came here to learn... to serve, and to see the world as you see it. Whatever task you have for me, I will do my best to fulfill it."

gesture: a movement of the hand or body used to express meaning
intrigued: very interested and curious

For a long, tense moment, the Khan said nothing. The court fell silent, all eyes on Marco, waiting, watching. Then, slowly, a smile crept across Kublai's face. "Very well," he said, his voice smooth but filled with power. "We shall see what you are capable of. You will serve in my court, young Marco. And in time, we will know if your curiosity and courage are as great as your words." The hall buzzed with whispers. Marco's heart soared. He had done it! He had proven himself worthy to stand in the court of Kublai Khan.

But even as excitement surged through him, a small flicker of doubt remained. What would serving in the court truly mean? What demands would the Khan place upon him? The days that followed were unlike anything Marco had ever experienced. He was drawn into the daily workings of the Khan's vast empire—its politics, its wealth, and its intrigues. The Great Khan, for all his **splendor**, was a ruler who demanded loyalty, intelligence, and results.

Serving him was no simple task. Every move, every word in the court was watched, weighed, and judged. Power here was not just held—it was constantly shifting, like the sands of the desert. Marco found himself at the center of it all. Kublai often called on him, testing his knowledge, his ability to observe and learn.

Marco studied the customs of the court, the languages, and the laws that governed the empire. He listened carefully, learned quickly, and slowly, he began to understand the complexities of the world he had entered. But with privilege came danger. Not all in the court looked kindly on an outsider from the West.

There were whispers in the shadows, jealous eyes that watched Marco's every move. He had risen quickly in the Khan's favor... too quickly, perhaps. And so, as Marco stood amidst the **splendor** of the Great Khan's court, he realized that his journey had only just begun. The path ahead was filled with both opportunity... and **peril**. Could he rise to the challenges, or would he be swept away by the tides of empire? Only time would tell.

splendor: great beauty that attracts admiration
peril: serious danger or risk

Exercisers Chapter 7

A. Meaning Choice

Choose the correct answer.

1. **Opulence** refers to:
a) danger and fear
b) simple living
c) great wealth and luxury

2. If someone looks **unreadable**, they are:
a) easy to understand
b) hard to understand
c) very talkative

3. **Peril** means:
a) comfort
b) success
c) serious danger

4. **Splendor** describes:
a) great beauty
b) loud noise
c) confusion

Answers:

1.c 2.b 3.c 4.a

B. Fill in the Blanks

Use the correct word from the list.

1. The palace was filled with gold and silk, showing great _____.
2. Marco felt a sense of _____ as he waited to speak to the Khan.
3. Kublai Khan's _____ eyes made Marco feel small and nervous.
4. Serving in the court brought honor, but also great _____.
5. The emperor's power _____ from his calm and confident presence.

Answers:

1. opulence 2. anticipation 3. piercing 4. peril 5. radiated

C. True or False

1. Vast means very small in size.
2. Someone who is intrigued feels curious and interested.
3. A gesture is always spoken, never physical.
4. Splendor can describe something impressive and beautiful.

Answers:

1. False
2. True
3. False
4. True

Chapter 8: "The Emperor's Mission... A Journey of Trust"

The Khan... was impressed. Marco could hardly believe it. The Great Khan—Kublai himself—had looked into Marco's eyes and seen something worthy of trust, something worthy of responsibility. But this... this was no ordinary **mission**. It was a task of great importance, one that required both courage and cunning, a test that would either solidify Marco's place in the Khan's court... or end in disaster.

As Marco sat astride his horse, the vast Mongol Empire stretched out before him, its lands rolling on endlessly into the horizon. Mountains loomed in the distance, rivers cut through the plains, and the sky—so wide, so vast—felt as if it belonged to the Khan himself. The power of Kublai Khan was visible in every corner of this land, and now Marco was riding under his gaze. Every hoofbeat echoed with the weight of expectation.

The **mission** was simple on the surface. Kublai Khan had **entrusted** Marco with delivering a message to a distant governor, deep in the heart of the empire. But this was no ordinary message. It was a political maneuver, **delicate** and dangerous, a move that could shift the balance of power. Marco knew that if anything went wrong... if he failed to deliver the message correctly... the **consequences** would be severe.

Not just for him, but for the Khan's entire empire. As the wind whipped through Marco's hair and the hooves of his horse pounded against the earth, his mind raced. Why me? he wondered. Why had Kublai chosen him, a young Venetian, for a task that required such precision? Was it a sign of trust, or... was it a test?

The Khan had spoken to him privately the night before, his voice low and measured. "Marco," he had said, his eyes sharp, "you have proven yourself observant, clever... but now, I must know if you are also **loyal**. You will take this message to my governor in the city of Khotan. He must understand its meaning. This is not a task for anyone. It is for you."

Those words had echoed in Marco's mind ever since. **Loyal**. The Khan needed to know if he could be trusted. But more than that—if Marco succeeded, it would mean something far greater. It would mean that Kublai Khan saw him not just as a traveler or a guest, but as a man of the empire... a man with a place in this vast, untamed world. As Marco rode through the dusty plains, the **enormity** of the task weighed on him. Khotan was far.

mission: an important task given to someone
entrusted: gave responsibility or care to someone
delicate: needing careful handling
consequences: results of an action, often serious
loyal: faithful and supportive
enormity: the great size or importance of something

The journey would take days, maybe weeks. He would cross rivers, pass through strange lands, and navigate the vast stretches of the empire, all under the watchful eye of those who would not hesitate to see him fail. The Mongol Empire was not a place of softness. It was a place of strength, and failure was not tolerated.

If he succeeded, he would earn something priceless: the Khan's trust. But if he failed… He swallowed hard. Failure wasn't an option. Not here. The road was long, the days hot and **unrelenting**. Dust clung to his clothes, and the sun beat down on his back. But Marco pressed on, his eyes fixed on the horizon.

He had survived the deserts, the mountains, the political intrigue of the court… and now he would survive this. But as the journey wore on, doubt began to creep in. The path was dangerous—filled with bandits, wild animals, and the unpredictability of the land itself. More than once, Marco's hand reached for the sword at his side as he heard strange noises from the brush, shadows moving in the distance.

He couldn't trust anyone out here. The Khan had powerful enemies, and those enemies would be more than happy to see his messenger disappear. One evening, as the sun dipped low and the sky turned a deep crimson, Marco made camp by a river. The water's surface shimmered like glass, reflecting the fiery sky above. But despite the beauty of the moment, Marco couldn't shake the feeling that he was being watched.

His senses, sharpened by months of travel, were on edge. Suddenly, a rustling in the trees caught his attention. His heart raced. He stood quickly, his hand on the hilt of his sword, eyes scanning the darkening woods. Was it an animal? Or something more dangerous? Out of the shadows stepped a man—dressed in the simple garb of a traveler, but with eyes that glittered with something more **sinister**. Marco's breath caught. Bandits.

The man smiled, though there was no warmth in it. "You're far from home, Venetian," he said, his voice low and dangerous. "Carrying something important, I imagine?" Marco's grip tightened on his sword, his mind racing. He knew what this was—a test, a challenge. The Khan's enemies were everywhere, and this man wanted something. The message.

The very thing Kublai had entrusted to him. But Marco couldn't fail. He wouldn't. "You're mistaken," Marco said, his voice steady despite the fear that crept into his chest. "I'm just a traveler… nothing more." The bandit's eyes narrowed. He took a step closer, his hand resting on a dagger at his side.

unrelenting: continuing without stopping
sinister: appearing evil or dangerous

“Do not lie to me. The roads are dangerous, and you look too confident for just a traveler.” Time seemed to slow. Marco knew he had to act, and fast. With a swift movement, he drew his sword, the blade gleaming in the dying light. “If you want what I carry, you’ll have to take it from me.” The bandit hesitated.

Clearly, he hadn’t expected resistance. And in that moment of hesitation, Marco moved. With a sharp strike, he disarmed the bandit, his blade flashing in the fading sun. The man stumbled backward, his eyes wide with shock. “Go,” Marco said, his voice calm but firm. “Before I change my mind.” The bandit, defeated, scurried back into the shadows, disappearing as quickly as he had come.

Marco stood there for a moment, his sword still raised, his heart pounding. The message… was safe. For now. As the night deepened, Marco sat by the fire, his thoughts heavy. He had passed the first test, but the journey wasn’t over yet. The Khan’s message still weighed heavily in his satchel, and Khotan was still days away.

But now, more than ever, Marco understood the **gravity** of the mission. This wasn’t just a journey of distance… it was a journey of trust. Kublai Khan was watching, even from afar. Every step Marco took, every decision he made, was being measured. Failure was not an option. As the days passed, Marco pressed on, his **resolve** growing stronger with each mile.

He crossed rivers, climbed mountain passes, and navigated the vast plains of the Mongol Empire, knowing that every step brought him closer to his goal. And finally, after what felt like an eternity, the city of Khotan appeared on the horizon. His heart leaped. He had made it. Now, the real test would begin.

As Marco rode through the gates of Khotan, the weight of the message in his satchel felt heavier than ever. He had traveled across the vast empire, under the watchful eye of the Khan, and now… now he would prove that he was worthy of the Great Khan’s trust. And with that, Marco Polo stepped into the unknown once again, ready to face whatever challenges lay ahead.

resolve: strong determination
gravity: seriousness or importance of a situation

Exercisers Chapter 8

A. Meaning Choice

Choose the correct answer.

1. A **mission** is:
a) a casual trip
b) an important task
c) a celebration

2. If something is **delicate**, it must be handled:
a) roughly
b) quickly
c) carefully

3. Resolve means:
a) fear
b) strong determination
c) confusion

4. A **sinister** person seems:
a) friendly
b) dangerous
c) tired

Answers:

1.b **2.**c **3.**b **4.**b

B. Fill in the Blanks

Use the correct word from the list.

1. The Khan _____ Marco with a dangerous task.
2. Marco understood the _____ of his responsibility.
3. The road was long and _____, with no rest from the heat.
4. Every action had serious _____ for the empire.
5. Marco's _____ grew stronger with every challenge.

Answers:

1. entrusted **2.** gravity **3.** unrelenting **4.** consequences **5.** resolve

C. True or False

1. **Loyal** means faithful and supportive.
2. **Enormity** describes something small and unimportant.
3. A **delicate** situation requires care.
4. **Sinister** describes something harmless.

Answers:

1. True
2. False
3. True
4. False

Chapter 9: "The Road to Cathay... Treasures and Perils"

Cathay! The very name stirred something deep within Marco's soul, a fire of wonder and **ambition** that had burned since the day he first set foot on this journey. It was a land whispered about in every corner of the known world—a kingdom of unimaginable riches, where golden temples stood tall, where silks as soft as water flowed through the streets, and where the Great Khan ruled with a hand both firm and wise.

Cathay! The fabled land that held the treasures of the East... and now, for the first time, Marco Polo was about to see it with his own eyes. As Marco and his caravan approached the borders of this magnificent kingdom, his heart raced with a mixture of excitement and fear. The road to Cathay had not been easy. The deserts, the mountains, the rivers—all had tested him. But this... this was different.

Now he was stepping into the heart of the East, a world he had only dreamed of, filled with both beauty and danger. The first sight of Cathay's grandeur came slowly, like the unfolding of a painting. Golden temples glittered in the distance, their roofs catching the light of the midday sun. Silken banners fluttered in the breeze, their colors so vibrant they seemed to breathe with life.

The cities were bustling, markets overflowing with goods Marco had never imagined—spices that filled the air with their rich scents, jewels that sparkled like stars, and fabrics so fine they slipped through his fingers like air. Everywhere he looked, there was something new, something **astonishing**. But beneath the surface, Marco could feel it... the **tension**.

There were eyes watching him. Unseen, but there. The road to Cathay was not only one of wonders, but of perils. Danger lurked in the shadows, hidden beneath the veil of beauty and riches. As Marco entered the city of Cambulac, the very heart of Cathay, the **grandeur** almost overwhelmed him.

The streets were alive with people—traders, merchants, nobles dressed in silks of every color. The air was thick with the scent of incense, mingling with the sweet aroma of food being sold in the markets. But Marco's eyes, sharp from months of travel, noticed more than just the splendor. There were figures in the corners, faces hidden beneath hoods, watching him too closely. Whispers followed him wherever he went.

ambition: a strong desire to achieve something important
grandeur: great beauty or impressive size
astonishing: very surprising or impressive
tension: a feeling of stress or hidden conflict

His father, Niccolò, and uncle, Maffeo, had warned him. “Cathay is a land of wonders,” Niccolò had said, “but it is also a land of politics, of webs spun so finely that even the slightest wrong move could trap you.” Marco knew that every step he took here would be watched, every word he spoke weighed. This was no ordinary kingdom.

It was a place where **alliances** were made and broken in the shadows, where loyalty was a **delicate** thread, easily snapped. Still, Marco pressed on. The road had been long, but he was determined to uncover the mysteries of Cathay. His ambition, the fire that had driven him all the way from Venice, burned hotter than ever.

He could feel it in his bones—he was on the verge of something great, something far beyond the treasures of gold and silk. One afternoon, Marco found himself in the bustling markets of Cambulac, surrounded by the vibrant sounds and colors of the city.

He marveled at the goods being traded—jewels of impossible beauty, spices so rich they filled the air with warmth, and fabrics that shimmered like water. But even as he admired the riches of Cathay, he couldn’t shake the feeling that someone was watching him… following him. His eyes darted around, scanning the crowded marketplace. There!

A figure, dressed in plain robes, moved through the crowd with purpose, always staying just out of reach. Marco’s heart quickened. Was this one of the Khan’s men? Or perhaps a spy, sent by those who wished to see him fail? He continued walking, his pace steady but his mind racing. Who could he trust? The Great Khan had many enemies, and the road to Cathay was littered with those who would do anything to gain favor or power.

Marco knew that his position at the Khan’s court had drawn attention. But from whom? And why? The figure followed him for what felt like hours, always staying just far enough away to remain unseen by others, but close enough for Marco to feel the weight of their gaze. Finally, Marco had had enough.

He turned sharply, ducking into a narrow alley, his heart pounding in his chest. He waited, breath held, listening for the sound of footsteps behind him. And then… silence. The figure had vanished. Marco exhaled slowly, his muscles tense. This was a warning, he realized. A reminder that Cathay, for all its beauty and treasures, was also a kingdom of secrets. He would have to be careful here.

One wrong move, and the glittering wonders of the East could easily turn into a trap. But Marco was not easily **deterred**. He had come too far to be frightened off by shadows. The Great Khan himself had invited him into this world, and Marco was determined to prove his worth. He continued to explore the city, speaking with merchants, learning the ways of the people, and soaking in the splendor of the East.

alliances: agreements or relationships formed for support
delicate: easily damaged or requiring careful handling
deterred: prevented or discouraged from doing something

His curiosity drove him forward, always seeking more, always looking beyond the surface. One evening, as the sun dipped low and the sky turned a deep shade of violet, Marco found himself standing at the gates of one of the Khan's great palaces. The golden rooftops gleamed in the fading light, and the banners fluttered softly in the evening breeze.

He could hear the faint sound of music coming from within the palace walls—a melody that seemed to echo the very heartbeat of Cathay itself. But even in this moment of wonder, Marco's mind was sharp. He had learned much in his time here. The treasures of Cathay were not only found in its markets or palaces. The true treasures... were the secrets, the knowledge, the power that lay hidden behind the walls of the empire.

To survive here, Marco would need more than ambition. He would need **cunning**, patience, and above all, trust in himself. As he stood there, the wind brushing against his face, Marco realized something important. This journey was not just about riches. It was about understanding—understanding the heart of Cathay, the mind of the Khan, and the dangers that lurked in the shadows.

It was about uncovering the mysteries that lay beneath the surface, and navigating the political webs that threatened to ensnare him at every turn. The road to Cathay had been filled with perils, but Marco had made it. Now, standing at the gates of the Great Khan's palace, he knew that his journey was far from over. The real test... had only just begun.

cunning: skillful in achieving goals, sometimes through clever or secret actions

Exercisers Chapter 9

A. Meaning Choice

Choose the correct answer.

1. Ambition is:
a) fear of danger
b) strong desire to succeed
c) sudden happiness

2. Something **astonishing** is:
a) boring
b) very impressive
c) familiar

3. Lurking means:
a) waiting openly
b) hiding and watching
c) traveling quickly

4. Alliances are:
a) personal thoughts
b) secret weapons
c) agreements between groups

Answers:

1.b **2.**b **3.**b **4.**c

B. Fill in the Blanks

Use the correct word from the list.

1. Marco's _____ pushed him to explore Cathay despite the dangers.
2. The city's _____ amazed him with its beauty and wealth.
3. He felt a sense of _____ as unseen eyes watched him.
4. Power in Cathay depended on fragile _____ between leaders.
5. Marco knew he could not be easily _____ by fear.

Answers:

1. ambition **2.** splendor **3.** tension **4.** alliances **5.** deterred

C. True or False

1. **Cunning** means being clever and strategic.
2. **Grandeur** describes something small and simple.
3. **Delicate** situations require careful action.
4. **Lurking** means being clearly visible.

Answers:

1.True
2.False
3.True
4.False

Chapter 10: "The Kingdom of Gold and Silk... And the Price of Loyalty"

Marco Polo was no longer just a wide-eyed traveler in awe of the East. In Cathay, he had risen to a new station... an **advisor** to the Great Khan himself. The boy from Venice, who had once only dreamed of adventure, now stood at the heart of an empire—an empire draped in gold and silk, where power whispered behind every corner and shadows moved with unseen purpose. But with power came peril.

The deeper Marco stepped into the world of the Khan's court, the more dangerous it became. **Loyalties**... they were fragile things. And trust? Trust was as rare as the precious stones that lined the Khan's palaces. Marco could feel the weight of it every day. The court was a place of grandeur, yes, but beneath the surface, it was a battlefield. Alliances were made in secret, broken with a smile, and rebuilt with a single, well-placed word.

Nobles from every corner of the empire vied for the Khan's favor, each with their own hidden **agenda**. Marco had learned to navigate this world, to speak with care, to observe... but the stakes were rising, and the cost of failure was now deadly. It started with a whisper—just a murmur in the halls of the palace. A rumor. A plot against the Khan. Marco had seen the way some of the nobles looked at him, the way their eyes lingered too long, their smiles too cold.

He had been a foreigner when he arrived, and to some, he would always be an outsider... no matter how close he stood to the Khan. One afternoon, as Marco sat in the Great Hall, watching as the Khan held council with his **advisors**, a chill crept over him. He could feel it—the tension in the air. The room was filled with silk-clad nobles, their robes shimmering with gold and jewels, but their faces were masks of politeness hiding something far darker.

Kublai Khan, seated on his throne, listened as a high-ranking official from one of the provinces spoke of **rebellion** brewing on the empire's edge. The Khan's eyes were sharp, his expression calm, but Marco knew the danger was real. As the meeting came to a close, Marco caught the eye of one of the court's most powerful figures—Chaghan, a nobleman whose influence had grown rapidly in recent months.

Chaghan's gaze lingered on Marco, his lips curling into a smile that sent a shiver down Marco's spine. There was something in that smile... a challenge? A threat? Later that evening, Marco was approached by one of Chaghan's men. The message was clear: "Meet me by the river at dusk. There are things you need to know." Marco's heart raced as he read the note, the words twisting in his mind.

advisor: a person who gives guidance or recommendations
loyalties: feelings of strong support or faithfulness
agenda: a hidden plan or personal goal
rebellion: organized resistance against authority

What could Chaghan want from him? Was this an opportunity... or a trap? The sun had barely set when Marco arrived at the riverbank, the air cool and quiet. Chaghan was already there, his **silhouette** outlined by the soft glow of lanterns along the water's edge. He greeted Marco with that same smile—smooth, but unreadable.

"You've made quite a name for yourself in the Khan's court, young Venetian," Chaghan said, his voice soft but filled with meaning. "The Khan values you... trusts you. That is not something to be taken lightly." Marco nodded, unsure where this conversation was headed, but every instinct told him to tread carefully.

"There are those," Chaghan continued, stepping closer, "who believe the Khan's vision for the empire is... flawed. That his rule has stretched too far, too thin. They whisper of change. A new order. But to make that happen, we need... allies. Men with influence. Men who are trusted by the Khan." The weight of Chaghan's words hung in the air. Marco felt his pulse quicken. Was this... was this an offer of betrayal? "You want me to turn against the Khan?" Marco asked, his voice steady but his mind racing.

Chaghan's smile didn't falter. "I want you to survive. The Khan's enemies are growing bolder. You have risen far, Marco, but in this court, one wrong move can cost you everything. I am offering you a chance to choose the winning side." For a moment, the world seemed to still. Marco's mind spun with the gravity of the choice laid before him.

If he sided with Chaghan and the plot succeeded, he could secure a powerful position in a new **regime**. But if he stayed loyal to the Khan... if Chaghan's plot failed... the **consequences** could be deadly. The Great Khan had given Marco everything—a place in his court, a role of importance in his empire. But was loyalty worth dying for?

"I cannot **betray** the Khan," Marco said at last, his voice firm, though his heart pounded in his chest. "He has trusted me, and I will not turn my back on him." Chaghan's smile faded slightly, replaced by a cold, **calculating** expression. "Loyalty is a noble thing, Marco. But in this world... loyalty has a price." Without another word, Chaghan turned and disappeared into the shadows, leaving Marco alone by the river, the weight of his decision pressing down on him.

The days that followed were tense. Marco knew that Chaghan's offer had not been idle words. The Khan's enemies were everywhere, their influence spreading like a shadow across the court. And Marco... Marco had chosen his side. But the question remained: Had he chosen wisely? One evening, Marco was summoned to the Khan's private chambers. The Great Khan, seated before a map of his vast empire, motioned for Marco to sit beside him.

silhouette: a dark shape seen against light
betray: to be disloyal or turn against someone
regime: a system or government in power
consequences: results or effects of an action
calculating: carefully planned for personal advantage

“I have heard… whispers,” the Khan said, his voice calm but filled with unspoken meaning. “There are those who believe I have lost control of my empire, that I am too distant from the struggles of my people.” Marco’s heart thudded in his chest. Did the Khan know about Chaghan’s plot? Was this a test? “The empire is vast,” Marco replied carefully, “but your rule is strong. Your people respect you.”

The Khan nodded, though his eyes remained focused on the map before him. “I need men I can trust, Marco. Men who will stand by me, even when others seek to tear down what I have built.” Marco met the Khan’s gaze, his decision clear in his mind now. “You have my loyalty, Great Khan. Always.” The Khan smiled, a faint but genuine expression. “I know.”

As Marco left the chambers that night, he felt both a sense of relief and a lingering sense of danger. He had made his choice. He had chosen loyalty… but in the court of the Khan, nothing was ever simple. The shadows still moved, the whispers still echoed, and the price of loyalty was yet to be fully paid. In the kingdom of gold and silk, Marco Polo had secured his place. But he knew… the cost of that place could be higher than he ever imagined.

Exercisers Chapter 10

A. Meaning Choice

Choose the correct answer.

1. An **advisor** is someone who:
a) gives orders
b) offers guidance
c) follows rules

2. Peril means:
a) safety
b) wealth
c) serious danger

3. A **regime** is:
a) a personal belief
b) a system of rule
c) a market place

4. To **betray** someone is to:
a) protect them
b) ignore them
c) turn against them

Answers:

1.b **2.**c **3.**b **4.**c

B. Fill in the Blanks

Use the correct word from the list.

1. Marco became an important _____ in the Khan's court.
2. Court politics were full of _____ and hidden threats.
3. Some nobles had a secret _____ they did not reveal openly.
4. Chaghan warned Marco that loyalty had serious _____.
5. From the shadows, a dark _____ appeared by the river.

Answers:

1.advisor **2.**peril **3.**agenda **4.**consequences **5.**silhouette

C. True or False

1. Loyalties can be fragile in dangerous political environments.
2. Rebellion means complete obedience to authority.
3. A calculating person plans actions carefully for advantage.
4. A silhouette is clearly detailed and brightly lit.

Answers:

1. True
2. False
3. True
4. False

Chapter 11: "Return to Venice... The Hero or the Dreamer?"

Years had passed... and the Marco Polo who returned to Venice was no longer the boy who had once stood at the harbor, gazing out at the ships with a heart full of dreams. No... the man who stepped onto Venetian soil now had seen the world—traveled farther than most men dared to dream.

But as the familiar canals of Venice came into view, a question lingered in the air, like a shadow following his every step: Had the world changed him? Or had he changed the world? The city welcomed him back with a mixture of curiosity and **skepticism**. Word had spread like wildfire through the narrow streets: Marco Polo has returned! But the **whispers**... the **whispers** were not all filled with praise.

Some called him a hero—a man who had braved the unknown, who had walked in the courts of emperors, seen the riches of Cathay, and returned with stories that dazzled the imagination. Others, however... others called him a dreamer. “A dreamer, spinning tales too grand for reality,” they whispered behind his back. How could one man have seen so much?

Golden temples, silken cities, an empire that stretched across the very ends of the earth? To many, it seemed impossible—too **fantastical** to believe. Marco could feel their eyes on him as he walked through the crowded markets, through the narrow alleys where he had once played as a child. The city felt smaller now, confined, compared to the vastness he had known. But it was home... his home.

The air smelled of salt and sea, the familiar sounds of the gondoliers calling out in the canals, and yet... Venice felt different. Or maybe it was Marco who had changed. He had left Venice as a boy, full of ambition, eager to follow in his father’s footsteps and see the world beyond the horizon. And what a world he had seen! The golden rooftops of Cathay’s palaces... the bustling markets filled with treasures and spices... the majestic presence of Kublai Khan himself, a ruler whose power stretched across empires.

Marco had witnessed it all. He had served in the court of the Khan, navigated the treacherous politics of the East, and survived the dangers that lurked at every turn. He had lived the life of a traveler, an explorer... a witness to wonders. But now, back in Venice, the world felt smaller again. His family welcomed him with open arms, his father and uncle standing proudly beside him as they recounted their travels to those who would listen.

skepticism: doubt about whether something is true
whispers: quiet, secret talk
fantastical: very imaginative and unlikely

But even as they spoke of their adventures, Marco could hear the whispers of doubt weaving through the crowd. “Is it true?” a man asked, his voice skeptical. “Did you really see the Great Khan? Did you walk through cities made of gold?” Marco turned to face him, his gaze steady. “Yes,” he said simply. “I have seen the East… and it is greater than anything you can imagine.”

But the man only shook his head, his **disbelief** clear. “Too many tales,” he muttered, walking away. “Too many stories.” And there it was—the doubt that clung to Marco like a second skin. The people of Venice had not seen what he had seen. To them, his stories were just that… stories.

How could they believe in lands so far away, in cities filled with wonders they could never dream of? To them, it was easier to believe that Marco Polo was just a dreamer—someone who had spun a web of fantasy too far from reality. But Marco… Marco knew his truth.

He had seen the golden banners fluttering in the wind above the Khan’s palace. He had walked the streets of Cathay, where merchants traded silks and spices from every corner of the world. He had sat at the table of Kublai Khan, heard the emperor’s voice, **witnessed** his wisdom. These were not dreams. These were his memories, his truth. No matter what others thought, no matter how they doubted, he knew what he had seen.

One evening, as Marco stood by the water’s edge, the sun setting over the Grand Canal, he felt the weight of it all—the years of travel, the miles he had crossed, the dangers he had faced. His journey had been long, filled with triumph and peril. But now… standing here, back where it had all begun, he wondered: Was it enough? Venice was beautiful, yes, but Marco could no longer see it the way he once had.

The city’s canals, the narrow alleys, the grand palazzos—they all felt so small now, so **confined**. The world was so much bigger than this. He had walked its **vastness**, crossed its deserts, climbed its mountains, and sailed its seas. He had **witnessed** the splendor of empires, and in doing so, he had become more than just a traveler. He had become a man who had lived a thousand lives in the span of one.

But the people… they could not understand. How could they? The world Marco had seen was too far, too distant. And so, they called him a dreamer. “Let them doubt,” Marco whispered to himself, his voice low but **resolute**. “Let them question. It does not change what I know.” As the days turned into weeks, and the weeks into months, Marco found himself retelling his stories again and again.

confined: limited in space or freedom
vastness: the quality of being extremely large
witnessed: saw something happen
disbelief: inability to believe something
resolute: firm and determined

Some listened with wide eyes, captivated by his tales of the East. Others, more skeptical, **dismissed** them with a wave of the hand. But Marco had made peace with it. The doubt no longer bothered him. For he knew... the truth lay not in what others believed, but in what he had lived. He had seen the world in all its glory, its vastness, its beauty.

He had stood in the court of the Great Khan, witnessed the riches of Cathay, and navigated the perils of the road. He had followed his dream, chased it across deserts and mountains, and returned with more than just stories. He had returned with knowledge, with experience... with the **proof** that the world was far greater than anyone could imagine.

And so, whether they called him hero or dreamer, Marco knew one thing for certain: He had lived a life that few could ever dream of. He had seen the East, touched its treasures, and walked in the footsteps of kings. No one could ever take that from him.

dismissed: decided something was not important
proof: clear evidence that something is true

Exercisers Chapter 11

A. Meaning Choice

Choose the correct answer.

1. **Skepticism** means:
a) strong belief
b) doubt
c) excitement

2. Something **fantastical** is:
a) very realistic
b) ordinary
c) highly imaginative

3. **Confined** describes something that is:
a) open and wide
b) restricted
c) dangerous

4. **Resolute** means:
a) uncertain
b) tired
c) determined

Answers:

1.b 2.c 3.b 4.c

B. Fill in the Blanks

Use the correct word from the list.

1. Many people listened to Marco's stories with _____.
2. Some listeners showed clear _____ when he spoke.
3. Venice felt _____ after Marco had seen the wider world.
4. Marco remained _____ despite people doubting him.
5. His memories were his personal _____ of what he lived.

Answers:

1.skepticism 2.disbelief 3.confined 5.resolute 6.proof

C. True or False

1. Whispers are spoken loudly in public places.
2. Vastness describes something extremely large.
3. To dismiss something is to take it very seriously.
4. Marco witnessed life in Cathay himself.

Answers:

1. False
2. True
3. False
4. True

Chapter 12: "The Legacy of a Wanderer..."

Marco Polo's journeys had come to an end. The great deserts, the bustling markets of Cathay, the golden palaces of the East... all of it now lay behind him. But though his feet no longer tread the roads of distant lands, his stories lived on. They **echoed** in the halls of kings, whispered through the chambers of scholars, and filled the imaginations of dreamers who had never **ventured** beyond their own shores.

Marco Polo, the wanderer, the explorer, the Venetian who had seen the world. His tales of the East—of Kublai Khan, of the Silk Road, of treasures beyond imagination—spread like wildfire across Europe. But these stories weren't just tales... they were windows into a world most could never hope to see. The Book of the Marvels of the World—the **account** of his travels—had been written down, shared from one eager hand to the next.

People marveled at his descriptions of golden cities, of silken banners that stretched through bustling streets, of the majestic Khan who ruled over an empire that defied belief. It was as if Marco had **unlocked** a door, opening Europe's eyes to the vastness of the East. His words carried them across deserts, through mountain passes, and into lands where the rules of their small world no longer applied.

But as Marco grew older, sitting by the canals of Venice, his life quiet once more, one question always **lingered** in his mind... Had he truly uncovered all the secrets of the world? The days of travel seemed like a distant memory now. His body, once so full of youthful energy and ambition, had aged, but his mind—oh, his mind—still burned with the fire of curiosity.

He had seen so much, more than most men could ever dream of. Yet, there were moments, late at night, when he stared out at the stars and wondered... Were there still mysteries waiting beyond the horizon? Even in his old age, he could hear the call of the road.

The same call that had **beckoned** him as a boy, standing by the Venetian harbor, dreaming of far-off lands. It was a call that never truly left him, even after all his years of wandering. The world... it was vast. So vast. And even after everything he had seen, everything he had lived... he knew there was more. More wonders. More secrets. More to discover. But now, that task would fall to others.

ventured: traveled somewhere risky or unknown
echoed: repeated or sounded again
account: a written record or description
unlocked: opened access to something new
lingered: stayed for a long time
beckoned: called or attracted someone to come closer

Marco often thought about the next great traveler, the one who would pick up where he had left off. Would they venture even farther than he had? Would they uncover lands he had never reached, meet rulers more powerful than Kublai Khan? The thought thrilled him. The idea that the world was still full of places unseen, waiting for the next bold adventurer to set foot upon them.

He smiled at the thought... There are still mysteries to be found, he thought to himself, still treasures hidden beneath the sands, still stories waiting to be told. Venice had welcomed him back, yes, but it had never truly understood the **scope** of his journey.

He had brought the East to Europe—painted it in colors they had never seen, filled their minds with images of cities so grand they seemed impossible. Yet, for some, those images remained too fantastical, too distant to be real. They had called him a dreamer... perhaps even a liar. But that no longer mattered. He knew his truth. He had seen the East. He had stood in the court of the greatest ruler the world had ever known.

He had traveled the Silk Road, navigated perilous deserts, and walked among the golden temples of Cathay. No amount of doubt or disbelief could change what he had experienced. The world was a mystery, vast and untamed. And though Marco had **unveiled** part of it, there was still so much more. He had only scratched the surface.

As he sat by the window of his modest home, the sounds of Venice filling the air—the chatter of merchants, the soft lap of water against the docks—Marco closed his eyes and let his mind wander. He could almost hear the distant sounds of the Silk Road—the crunch of caravan wheels over dry earth, the calls of traders haggling over spices, the gentle flap of silken banners in the wind.

He could see the golden rooftops of Kublai Khan's palace shining in the sun, the endless deserts stretching out beneath a sky so vast it seemed to swallow the world whole. He could feel the wind of the mountains, cold and biting, and the warmth of the bustling markets of Cathay, filled with treasures from every corner of the earth. These memories were his treasures now.

His **legacy**. But as much as Marco had seen, as much as he had uncovered, he knew... the world's greatest mysteries still lay beyond the **horizon**. For him, the journey had ended. But for the next wanderer, the road was still open, waiting to be walked. Perhaps, one day, they too would stand in a far-off land, marveling at the wonders of the world, just as he had done all those years ago. The thought brought him peace.

legacy: something important left behind after a person's life
scope: the full size or extent of something
unveiled: revealed or showed clearly
horizon: the line where the earth seems to meet the sky

And so, the legend of Marco Polo—the wanderer, the explorer, the man who had dared to venture beyond the known world—would live on. His stories would continue to inspire kings, scholars, dreamers, and travelers alike. But Marco knew, deep in his heart, that the world's true story had only just begun.

There were still wonders to be discovered, still secrets hidden in the corners of the earth, waiting for the next brave soul to find them. And as Marco drifted off into the quiet of his final years, a smile played at the corners of his lips. The world was vast… and he had played his part. But the horizon… the horizon still called.

Exercisers Chapter 12

A. Meaning Choice

Choose the correct answer.

1. **Legacy** means:
a) a mistake
b) something left behind
c) a journey

2. To **venture** means to:
a) stay safe
b) return home
c) travel into the unknown

3. **Lingered** means:
a) disappeared quickly
b) stayed longer than expected
c) moved suddenly

4. **Unveiled** means:
a) hidden
b) destroyed
c) revealed

Answers:

1.b 2.c 3.b 4.c

B. Fill in the Blanks

Use the correct word from the list.

1. Marco Polo's stories became his lasting _____.
2. His words _____ through Europe for many years.
3. Few people had _____ beyond their own lands like Marco.
4. The book was an _____ of his travels.
5. The road to discovery stretched toward the distant _____.

Answers:

1. legacy 2. echoed 3. ventured 4. account 5. horizon

C. True or False

1. **Beckoned** means to push something away.
2. The **scope** of Marco's journey was very large.
3. **Unlocked** means to close something permanently.
4. Marco **unveiled** part of the world to Europe.

Answers:

1. False
2. True
3. False
4. True

Lesson 5: Parts of Speech – Pronouns

Pronouns are **words that replace nouns.**
They help us avoid repetition and make sentences smoother and clearer.

Instead of repeating the same noun again and again, we use a pronoun.

Example

Marco met the Khan. **Marco** spoke politely. ❌
Marco met the Khan. **He** spoke politely. ✅

1. Personal Pronouns

Personal pronouns change depending on **who** is doing the action.

Subject Pronouns (do the action)

I, you, he, she, it, we, they

Examples

I travel often.
She listens carefully.
They arrive at dawn.

Object Pronouns (receive the action)

me, you, him, her, it, us, them

Examples

The Khan trusted **him.**
The guide helped **us**.
Marco met **them**.

2. Possessive Pronouns

These pronouns show **ownership.**

mine, yours, his, hers, its, ours, theirs

Examples

This book is **mine**.
The palace was **his**.
The decision was **theirs.**

3. Demonstrative Pronouns

They point to **specific things.**

this, that, these, those

Examples

This is important.
Those are dangerous roads.

4. Reflexive Pronouns

They refer back to the **subject.**

myself, yourself, himself, herself, itself, ourselves, themselves

Examples

Marco prepared **himself.**
She blamed **herself**.

Common Pronoun Mistakes

❌ Marco spoke to she.
✅ Marco spoke to **her.**

❌ This book is her.
✅ This book is **hers.**

Exercises

A. Choose the Correct Pronoun

1. Marco trusted ___ with the mission.
a) he
b) him
c) his

2. The maps are ___.
a) them
b) theirs
c) they

3. ___ roads are very dangerous.
a) This
b) That
c) These

B. Fill in the Blanks

1. The Khan spoke to ____ kindly.
2. This decision is ____, not mine.
3. Marco prepared ____ for the journey.

C. True or False

1. Pronouns replace nouns.
2. “Hers” is a subject pronoun.
3. “Myself” is a reflexive pronoun.

Answers

A

b) him
b) theirs
c) these

B

1. him
2. yours
3. himself

C

1. True
2. False
3. True

About the Author

WooEnglish, an innovative educational platform, came into existence towards the end of 2019, right on the cusp of the unprecedented global pandemic. This period of immense change amplified the importance of online learning. Amid these shifting circumstances, WooEnglish discovered its unique purpose, carving out its own niche within the dynamic landscape of education.

Specializing in creating English teaching resources, WooEnglish has crafted a range of books targeted at English language learners of all levels. Each book is meticulously designed to provide an immersive language learning experience, making the journey of English language acquisition an engaging and enjoyable one.

The reach of WooEnglish extends far beyond its books. With a successful YouTube channel, WooEnglish has touched the lives of over 180,000 students from around the globe. The channel provides an interactive platform where students can practice the language through reading and listening exercises, utilizing the books included in the curriculum.

The response to this innovative method of language learning has been overwhelmingly positive, contributing to the growing popularity of WooEnglish among language learners. In addition to the YouTube channel, WooEnglish also hosts a comprehensive website.

It is a treasure trove of resources, containing books in various categories, all tailored for English language learners. From beginner to advanced level, there is something for every learner on this platform. WooEnglish is more than just an English teaching resource; it's a passionate endeavor aimed at making English language learning accessible and enjoyable for everyone, irrespective of their level of proficiency.

Committed to fostering an environment that encourages learning and growth, WooEnglish continues to innovate and expand its horizons, Every book we offer is a stepping stone in this journey, each one designed to enrich understanding and instill confidence in our learners.